

Two Long

Jen Morrison took the time to enjoy the warm reception she was getting as she entered the arena. Regardless of how this fight turned out, this had been an amazing run for her. The fans were letting her know they appreciated it, and she was giving it right back to them. Smiling and waving as she strode toward the cage, with Steph, Tiz and Marcy right behind her. There were no signs of the nervous tension she had to be carrying inside her. After all, this was her first title bout of any kind, and it had seemingly come out of nowhere. On top of that, she had never faced Keira Knightley before and she'd had barely a week to prepare. And have no doubt... Keira was the top seed for a reason. She had tons of experience against just about every type of fighter you could think of, and she had been overwhelmingly successful against most of them. So the task before was formidable to put it mildly, but Jen didn't look the slightest bit intimidated.

As for me, I had a few questions about whether or not she was ready for this. The first was simple. Was she really as confident as she looked, or would the moment be too much for her?

My answer came almost the second the bell rang. Instead of the tentative survivalist I think most were expecting, Jen came out the aggressor. It started harmlessly enough. A fairly lazy right kick aimed at Knightley's side, which Keira easily defended. But that was just the appetizer. Morrison got her foot down, shifted her balance and up came the other leg. High and hard, her foot connecting cleanly with Keira's face.

Clearly, Jen was not overwhelmed by the moment.

It was a tremendous blow that sent Knightley reeling, and it looked like this one might be over before it started.

Jen surged forward to press her advantage, but Keira was quick to show why she's one of the best. Instead of backing away and covering up, she stepped forward and met Jen's advance. Closing the distance too quickly for Jen to react. The move allowed Knightley to force the clinch. Then she showed her head was still in the fight, immediately tripping for the takedown.

The two crashed to the mat. Keira went for side control and got it with little resistance. She tried to progress to armbar, but Jen did a great job of wrenching her arm free and fighting her off. There was a little pushing and grinding, then Knightley went big... lurching around Morrison's legs in an attempt to get to mount. Again, Jen reacted beautifully... foiling the move by catching Keira in her guard as the opening minute ticked off the clock.

Keira fired down some punches and tried to grind her way past Jen's guard. Morrison struggled a bit, but maintained her defensive position. Then she showed another shot of that confidence she seemed to be full of as she tried to roll them both over. Knightley was focused on breaking down Jen's defense, so the reversal caught her by surprise. The move was quick and clean, and Jen had the position she wanted instantly.

Not that it did her any good.

Morrison was on top and in charge for nearly a full minute. Pounding down strikes and looking for ways to get the finish. But again, Keira wasn't new at this. She fought tooth and nail the whole time. Preventing Jen from doing any real damage. Finally Knightley was able to grapple things to a standstill, forcing the ref to intervene.

The women climbed back to their feet, and the fight resumed with just over two minutes gone.

Once again, Jen went straight after it. A straight right hand to the body, followed by another high kick. The right did some damage, but Knightley dodged the high kick then scored with a solid kick of her own to the outside of Jen's thigh.

Morrison kept coming. Faking the jab, then launching a right hook that Keira avoided.

This kind of in-your-face, push-the-action approach wasn't really Jen's style, and I was certain the idea had from Steph. Unfortunately, that only lent credence to the other big worry I had about this one because it meant Steph was thinking the same way.

Knightley stepped forward to try to take initiative. Jen countered with a knee to the body. Keira managed to sidestep the blow, but she was forced to give up on whatever she had in mind and back out.

The action cooled for a moment as Keira seemed satisfied with lurking just out of range as she considered her options. Unfortunately, Jen seemed content to wait around and let her.

The only thought I had at that second was *Uh, oh*.

As the three minute mark ticked by, Keira suddenly crouched and shot forward in an apparent takedown attempt. Jen countered with a kick that would have done some impressive damage, but Keira pulled up short and backed away.

I sensed the tide turning as Keira suddenly became more active. Dancing and feinting as she looked for an opening. Jen maintained space with her jab, but seemed reluctant to launch an attack of her own.

Keira turned the aggression up another notch. A feint drew out Jen's jab. Knightley blocked the punch aside, then threw a short left hook with the same hand. It was an unorthodox punch that lacked weight-driven power, but it was also foolproof. With her right arm knocked aside and her left arm in it's customary guard position, Jen was wide-open and the punch landed untouched. Keira tried to follow with a hook from the other side, but Jen felt it coming and retreated out of range.

That kind of instinctive move... predicting Keira's follow-up at a moment when she really couldn't see it coming... was champion-level stuff out of Jen. More importantly, she had now been in there for over three and a half minutes with the best fighter in her weight class, and Jen hadn't looked out of her depth for even a second. But now Keira's experience was starting to show through.

But what the hell does that mean, anyway?

As far as talent and technique went, Jen had already shown she was up to the task. Had shown it all throughout the tournament, as a matter of fact.

Was it a matter of handling the pressure of the moment? Sometimes, yes. But Jen had already put that concern to rest, as well.

So, what kind of experience did Knightley have that Jen lacked?

In this case, the problem wasn't a matter of training or mental composure. It was simple and tangible and as plain as the nose on your face.

Five minutes is longer than three.

Sounds a little stupid, right? I mean, two minutes? Seriously?

But when you're in there - grinding and grappling and scrapping for every inch - two minutes is a very long time. Fighters develop a flow in the cage that becomes second nature. They know how much they have to give, and they know how to parcel it out so they lay it all out there without running out of steam before the break. Jen had that flow down to a science... but only for a period of three minutes. It takes time and training to get used to the longer championship rounds. To get the mind and body used to having to go those extra two minutes. A week of prep is not enough to make that happen.

And Steph wasn't helping at all.

Not that she didn't try, of course. Since there was no way to prepare for the longer rounds, the only remaining plan was to do the exact opposite. To push the action and try to hurt Knightley early. To do as much damage as possible before Jen's energy started to flag.

Unfortunately, Keira and her team knew they had this advantage going for them, and their plan was to make the most of it. Keira had been patient and smart... staying defensive and taking few chances at the start of the round. She'd had to take a few lumps along the way, but now it was all coming together for her. The 'championship minutes' were clearly taking a toll on Jen. The all-out push hadn't really worked, and the effort had only sapped more of her energy. Meanwhile, Knightley still looked like she had a lot to give.

Jen kept pushing the action. Trying to do as much as she could with what she had left. She padded out a pair of jabs, then tried the right hook again. Keira saw it coming and swayed out of reach.

Jen came forward behind a low kick. Keira checked it with her shin, then a brief skirmish led to nothing and both backed away.

Jen's posture was slowly losing shape, and her tactics changed accordingly. As the two closed again, she got grabby... looking to pull Keira in and clinch to kill time. Keira kept her hands free and pushed her away.

A minute and fifteen seconds to go. Jen's fatigue manifested itself in the form of a sloppy, looping right hand. Knightley easily avoided it, then countered with a perfect one-two. Jen staggered, and Keira chased her down... scoring with a series of combinations before Morrison found her feet and circled out.

Jen tried another kick. Keira blocked it easily.

Jen went back to the right hook. Once again, it wasn't crisp. Keira caught it on her shoulder and answered with a fierce counter.

Jab, uppercut.

Both punches found their mark, with the uppercut doing obvious damage. Jen stumbled away but somehow gathered her defense before Knightley could follow-up.

I ran my fingers through my hair with an exasperated sigh. With forty-five seconds to go, this could get ugly.

Then Jen surprised me. As the two closed again, she spotted an opening and put a wicked right hand into it. Keira just managed to get her head out of the way and circled out, but the look on her face told me I wasn't the only one the blonde fighter had surprised.

After that came a lot of circling and jabbing that went nowhere, as even Keira seemed to be showing a little fatigue late in the round. But both fighters perked up as the ten second clacker sounded. Each looking to put her stamp on a round that was likely leaning Keira's way. There was lot of furious punching but it mostly went for naught, with neither scoring anything significant.

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The break was fairly routine in both corners. Knightley had scored with some hard shots in the closing minutes, and Marcy focused on controlling the swelling from that. Steph and Tiz seem to spend most of the time on encouragement. The plan in round one didn't go perfectly, but there was nothing inherently wrong with it, either. Jen seemed to match her opponent for the better part of the round before it slipped away from her in those closing minutes. A point lost, but not a catastrophe. So everybody was calm and cool. Things still seemed under control. But underneath, I think all involved knew the score. That catastrophe they'd avoided was still waiting just around the corner. Jen was pretty well spent, and a minute isn't much time to recuperate. On top of that, I knew Steph would be pushing for her to make another fast start in round two. It was really the only option. If Jen didn't get out there and do significant damage early, there was a good chance she wouldn't make it to the end.

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The second round was pretty much a disaster from the start. As expected, Jen came out punching at the bell. Trouble was, Keira's name was on the long list of people who had that expectation, and she was ready for it. She took a few punches on her guard, then found her opening and nailed Jen with a brutal right hook. Another stumbling exit for Jen, but she somehow pulled herself back together again.

Jen pressed again... pushing forward behind the jab, then launching a bone-shattering right hand. Keira dodged it and circled away.

Jen pursued... pushing her back with a series of big combinations. Keira calmly defended and jabbed her off.

I was starting to get a sinking feeling in the pit of my stomach. Jen was doing all she could, but she wasn't having any luck. Meanwhile, Keira seemed content to rely on her defense and wait until the moment was right. With barely a minute gone, she had plenty of time.

Another combo from Jennifer amounted to nothing. This time Keira saw an opportunity and fired back with an uppercut that landed perfectly. Jen backed away and got her defense back up as she tried to shake it off.

I had to give her one thing... Jen's instincts were pure gold. I was liking her chances in this one less and less with every second that ticked by, but the way she was surviving in there reminded me that she hadn't made it this far on luck. She was tapping into something. Pushing aside the ubiquitous *potential* label and showing real signs of the champion she just might be able to become. I just wanted to get her out of here in one piece so we could take her home, polish her up and maybe get a nice clear view of just what we had in her.

Speaking of instinct... Jen seemed to know she was already running out of steam. No way she was going to be able to grind Keira down. So instead, she went for broke. A quick fake jab, then a mighty high kick. All or nothing. It missed by a mile, and the door was left wide open. Knightley did not let the opportunity pass her by as she hammered a pair of hooks into Jen's ribs before she could jab her way out of there.

And that was pretty much the end of that, as Keira started to take over.

On the next exchange, a clearly flagging Jen tried to grapple. Like so many at RSI, she is a strike-first kind of fighter. So this was desperation, not strategy. It was akin to clinching in a boxing match. Just a way to buy some recovery time. But there was still three and a half minutes left in the round. Much more time than she could ever hope to kill. Especially since Knightley wasn't going to let herself get tangled up in the first place.

True to form, Keira pushed her off, then launched an attack of her own.

Jab, High kick.

I swear to you that her toenail grazed Jen's chin. That's how close she came to ending this fight right then and there.

After the near miss, Jen immediately tried to grapple again but Keira fought her off and kept the fight at striking range.

More credit to Jen... she refused to give up. Pressing the action wasn't working. Stalling the action wasn't working. But she kept coming... pushing forward and launching a few punches. Keira decided to trade with her and the younger brunette scored a flurry of solid punches.

Left, right, hook.

No instant replay was needed to see all three landed cleanly. Jen had her guard up, but she was moving like a turtle compared to Knightley.

The decision to stand and fight had me wondering. There were still more than two minutes to go, and letting Jen do all the work had been working pretty well for Keira so far. Why the sudden change?

The answer became obvious only a few seconds later.

Jen was beat up and worn out. Not only was she getting nowhere with her own strategy, but she had to know every second that passed meant she was playing right into Keira's hands. Knightley had been messing with her the entire round. Probably the entire fight. The only thing Jen had left was heart, and Keira had just taken the last of that from her. That last exchange was a clear demonstration that - while Jen was exhausted - Keira had plenty left in the tank. Keira had given Jen what she wanted. A chance to go toe-to-toe. Then she promptly gave her a quick ass-whipping for her trouble.

The message?

I can do this all day, baby. Can you?

The answer was no, and both of them knew it.

Desperate for a break, Jen looked to grapple again. This time, Keira was only too happy to oblige. Expecting a fight, Jen was completely taken by surprise, which allowed Keira to get the better position. Then came the knee strikes. One right after the other, brutally pounding into Jen's side. It only took a few before instinct overrode training and Jen brought her guard down in a desperate effort to make it stop. That opened a window for Keira to put her away.

Jab, uppercut.

Jen was so spent, it was like shooting fish in a barrel. The jab set her up, and the uppercut sent her straight to dreamland.

I shook my head in disappointment as the ref called off the fight and the medics and seconds poured in.

Despite the strategy and the confidence, Jen had never really been in this fight. She had done her best to overcome a glaring weakness, but it was impossible to do against a fighter like Keira. She needed a full bag of tools at her disposal for a fight like this, and she didn't have them. That's why I was disappointed. Not at Jen, but at us. We didn't expect her to get this far, so we'd failed to prepare her for the possibility.

It was something of a ridiculous thought. We had two dozen fighters to prepare for this event. With the way things were going, it was hard to argue we hadn't done a pretty damn good job.

But sitting here now... seeing Jen crumpled on the canvas like this... it was a hard thing to swallow. It was also a pretty shitty reward for all she'd done to get here.

I pushed my thoughts aside and shut my mind down. RSI had a long night ahead of it, and I had to clear my emotions before the next fight got started. Also, I needed to get past the outcome and see the bigger picture. Jen had done a lot of good at this event, and we wouldn't let that go to waste. She had smashed our expectations, and now we knew what she could do. We would help her get back here and take another shot at it.

And next time, she would be ready.